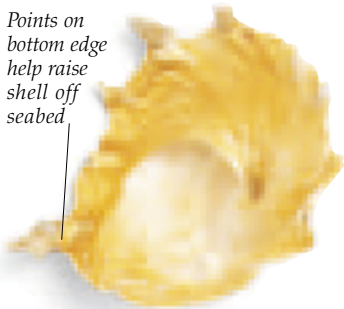
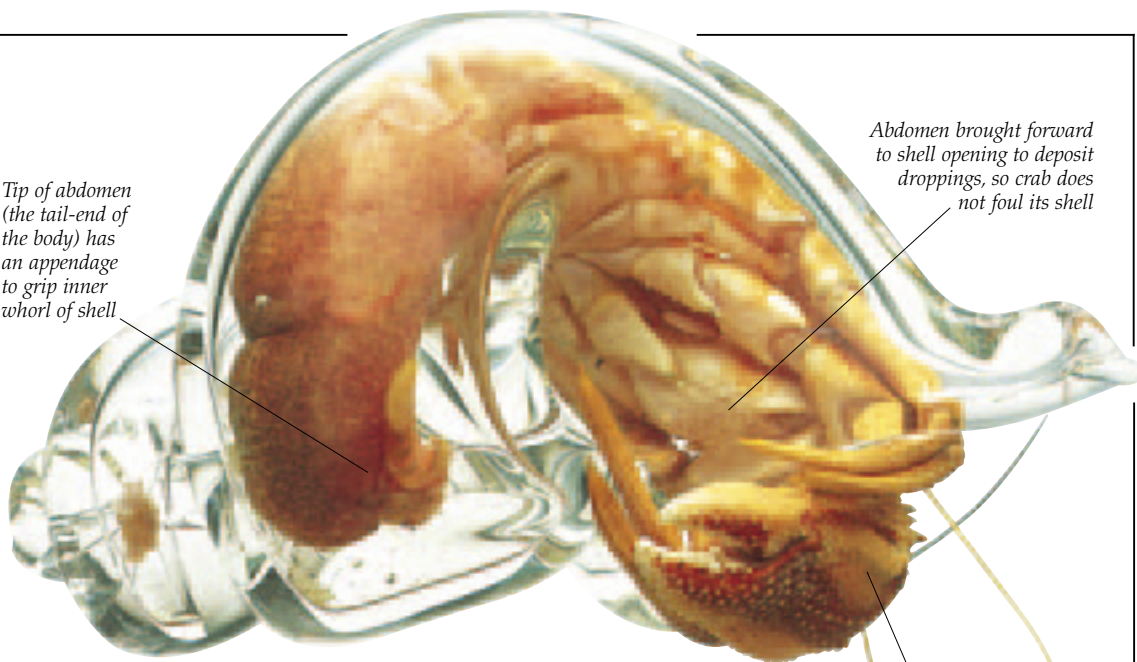


Points on bottom edge help raise shell off seabed



Tip of abdomen (the tail-end of the body) has an appendage to grip inner whorl of shell



Abdomen brought forward to shell opening to deposit droppings, so crab does not foul its shell

Pincer also used to pick up food

SHELLS ON SHELLS

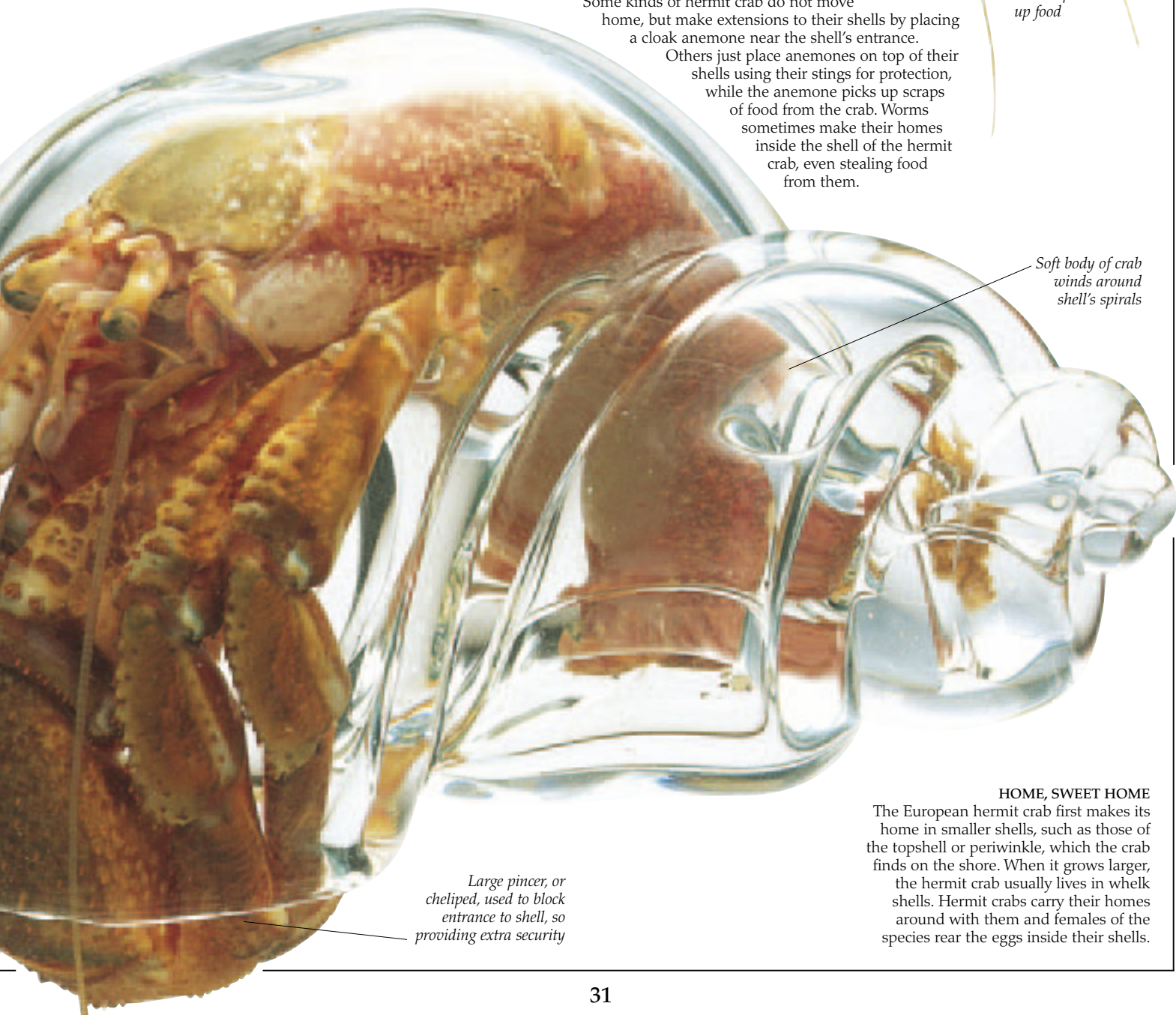
Carrier shells are sea snails that attach empty shells and bits of hard debris, including corals, pebbles, and even broken glass, to their own shells. This disguise is to hide them from predators such as fish. The extra projections may make it more difficult for predators to crack open the shells to reach the soft meat inside.

ANOTHER HOME

Some kinds of hermit crab do not move home, but make extensions to their shells by placing a cloak anemone near the shell's entrance.

Others just place anemones on top of their shells using their stings for protection, while the anemone picks up scraps of food from the crab. Worms sometimes make their homes inside the shell of the hermit crab, even stealing food from them.

Soft body of crab winds around shell's spirals



Large pincer, or cheliped, used to block entrance to shell, so providing extra security

HOME, SWEET HOME

The European hermit crab first makes its home in smaller shells, such as those of the topshell or periwinkle, which the crab finds on the shore. When it grows larger, the hermit crab usually lives in whelk shells. Hermit crabs carry their homes around with them and females of the species rear the eggs inside their shells.